

AJIT KUMAR NALAVADE, 35
Railway Police Constable LOCATION: CST

"I fired, but soon a bullet got stuck in my carbine"

Police Constable Nalavade, a hero in his own right, was one of the men responsible for neutralising the terror attack on CST on the night of November 26. At the railway police post when the terrorists opened fire on Platform No. 14 of the station, Nalavade and his colleagues first thought it was only a case of some sparking. "I went into the main hall but there was no one there. Finally, I spotted the terrorist on Platform No. 14," says Nalavade.



SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE

ERICA DI GIOVANCARLO, 44
Italian Trade Commissioner
LOCATION: Taj's Souk Restaurant

"We were told to wait till the army came to our rescue"

Erica Di Giovancarlo was at the Taj's Souk Restaurant with a friend when she learnt about the firing. "But that was when we were leaving at 11 p.m.," she recalls. Luckily, six guards on duty for South African cricketers were at the restaurant. "They escorted us to a ballroom to wait as we were told that we could not leave until the army arrived," says Giovancarlo. All along, the staff present kept them informed about the situation. At around 4 a.m., they were rescued as they climbed down 25 floors in batches through the fire exit. Once out, Giovancarlo's driver took her home. The experience shook her but she has no thoughts of leaving Mumbai.

SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE



DEEPAK and VINAY KUNTAWALA, 38 and 67, NRI
Businessmen LOCATION: Taj Mahal Hotel

"I tied curtains together to form a chain to escape"

When Vinay and Deepak Kuntawala, the NRI father-son duo from the UK, walked into the Sea Lounge at Taj Mahal Hotel after checking out, little did they realise a nightmare awaited them. Between 9.45 and 10 p.m. they saw two men and heard gunshots shortly after. "Soon the hotel staff sounded an alarm and told us not to go out," recalls Deepak, "they were very helpful, but did not tell us what was going on." He decided not to wait for the terrorists to come and got the others to help him. "I used metal vases to shatter the glass panes and tied the curtains together to form a chain." Over 45 guests used the chute to slip out of the Lounge.

